

Salary Negotiation Scripts: Word-for-Word for Every Situation

RenWork Digital Products

Responding to an Initial Job Offer

****The Opening Line:**** "Thank you for extending this offer. I am very excited about the role and the team's mission, and I've been reviewing the details to ensure we are aligned on long-term value."

****The Pivot:**** "While the base salary is within the range we discussed, my research into current market standards for this specific skill set, combined with my experience in [specific relevant achievement], suggests there is a gap between the current figure and the industry benchmark."

****The Ask:**** "Given my proven track record of [specific metric, e.g., increasing revenue by 20%], I would like to propose a base salary of \$X. I believe this adjustment reflects the immediate value I will bring to the team and sets a sustainable foundation for our partnership."

****Objection Handling 1 (Budget Constraints):****

"I understand budget cycles are rigid. If the base salary is strictly capped, could we discuss a significant signing bonus or a guaranteed performance review with a salary adjustment in six months?"

I am confident in my ability to justify the increase through performance metrics."

****Objection Handling 2 (Process Delays):****

"Completely understood. To keep momentum, could we hold this offer open for 48 hours while I finalize my decision? I am eager to move forward, but I want to ensure the compensation structure is fully transparent before I accept."

Counter-Offering Without Sounding Greedy

****The Opening Line:**** "I appreciate your patience while I considered the offer. I am genuinely enthusiastic about joining [Company Name] and contributing to [Project/Goal]."

****The Pivot:**** "However, when I compare this offer against my current compensation and the specific responsibilities outlined in the job description, particularly regarding [specific high-value duty], the current number does not fully reflect the scope of the role."

****The Ask:**** "To make this transition seamless and ensure I can focus entirely on delivering results, I am requesting a salary of \$X. This figure aligns with my past performance data and the market rate for senior-level contributors in this field."

****Objection Handling 1 (Comparison to Internal Equity):****

"I respect the need for internal equity. Could you share the specific criteria used for this role's compensation band? If the base is fixed, I'd like to explore additional equity or a higher commission structure that rewards performance rather than just tenure."

****Objection Handling 2 (Hiring Manager's Personal Stakes):****

"I understand this puts you in a difficult position. I'm not trying to complicate the process; I simply want to ensure the offer is competitive enough that I can accept it without hesitation. Is there flexibility in the non-cash components, such as remote work flexibility or professional development stipends, to bridge the gap?"

Asking for a Raise Mid-Year

****The Opening Line:**** "I've requested some time to discuss my recent contributions and career trajectory. I've been incredibly proud of our team's success in [Quarter/Project] and wanted to align on the value I've generated."

****The Pivot:**** "Since my last compensation review, I have taken on additional responsibilities, including [specific new task] and [specific new task], which have resulted in [specific positive outcome, e.g., saving 10 hours of weekly admin time]."

****The Ask:**** "Based on this expanded scope and the measurable impact I've had on [Key Metric], I am requesting a salary adjustment to \$X. This brings my compensation in line with the current market rate for my expanded role and reflects the increased value I deliver to the department."

****Objection Handling 1 (No Budget for Mid-Year Increases):****

"I understand budget cycles are quarterly. If a base salary increase isn't possible right now, could we document a guaranteed adjustment date of [Date, e.g., Q3] contingent on meeting [Specific KPI]? I want to ensure my compensation reflects my current level of responsibility, even if the timing is

delayed."

****Objection Handling 2 (Performance Concerns):****

"I welcome that feedback. I believe my recent metrics in [Area] demonstrate strong performance. Are there specific areas where you feel I haven't met expectations? I'd like to create a clear, written plan with measurable milestones that, upon achievement, would trigger the salary adjustment we discussed."

Negotiating Freelance Project Rates

****The Opening Line:**** "Thanks for the detailed brief. I'm confident I can deliver the high-quality [Deliverable] you're looking for within the proposed timeline."

****The Pivot:**** "However, based on the complexity of the [Specific Feature/Requirement] and the level of customization required, my standard project rate needs to be adjusted to cover the additional hours and expertise involved."

****The Ask:**** "I propose a fixed project fee of \$X. This includes two rounds of revisions and comprehensive documentation. If the scope remains as described in the brief, this fee ensures I can dedicate the necessary focus and expertise to meet your deadlines."

****Objection Handling 1 (Client Budget Limit):****

"If the budget is strictly limited to \$Y, we could adjust the scope. I can remove [Lower-Priority Item] or extend the timeline by two weeks. Which approach would you prefer: a reduced scope at the current budget, or the full scope at the proposed rate?"

****Objection Handling 2 (Comparison to Cheaper Vendors):****

"I understand price is a factor. While I may not be the lowest bid, my experience with [Specific Industry/Tool] reduces your risk of rework and ensures faster integration. My rate includes post-launch support for 30 days, which is not typically standard for lower-cost providers."

Asking for Equity

****The Opening Line:**** "I'm very excited about the long-term potential of [Company Name]. I see myself growing with the company and sharing in its success as it scales."

****The Pivot:**** "While the base salary is competitive, I'm looking at the total compensation package from a long-term perspective. Given the startup's trajectory and my role in building [Specific Core Function], I believe equity is a critical component of my motivation and alignment with the company's goals."

****The Ask:**** "I would like to discuss adding an equity package of [X%] or [Number of Shares] to my offer. I believe this aligns my incentives with the company's growth and demonstrates my commitment to its long-term success."

****Objection Handling 1 (Standard Equity Pool is Small):****

"I understand equity pools are finite. If the percentage is capped, could we discuss a higher vesting acceleration clause or a refresh grant opportunity in year two? I want to ensure the equity component is meaningful enough to reflect my seniority and impact."

****Objection Handling 2 (Valuation Uncertainty):****

"Fair point. To mitigate uncertainty, could we structure the equity with a clear liquidity event definition or a buyback provision? Alternatively, if equity is currently limited, could we increase the base salary slightly to account for the risk, with a promise to revisit equity once the next funding round is closed?"

Negotiating Benefits and PTO

****The Opening Line:**** "I'm eager to accept the role, and I've been reviewing the benefits package to understand the full scope of support the company provides."

****The Pivot:**** "I value work-life balance and comprehensive health coverage highly. While the salary is attractive, the current PTO structure and healthcare co-pays are more restrictive than what I'm accustomed to, which is a key factor for my long-term sustainability and productivity."

****The Ask:**** "Could we increase the PTO allowance to [X] days per year or provide a stipend of \$Y for wellness and health expenses? This adjustment would allow me to maintain the high energy and focus required for this role without burnout."

****Objection Handling 1 (Company Policy is Fixed):****

"I understand policy is company-wide. If PTO days are fixed, could we offer flexibility in how they are used, such as allowing unlimited PTO for specific quarters or offering a hybrid work model two days a week? This flexibility often outweighs a strict day count for many employees."

****Objection Handling 2 (Budget for Benefits is Tight):****

"If additional monetary benefits aren't feasible, could we include a one-time wellness stipend or a professional development budget of \$Z? These are lower-cost adjustments that significantly improve employee retention and satisfaction."

Handling 'That Is Our Final Offer'

****The Opening Line:**** "I appreciate your transparency and the finality of that position. I respect your constraints."

****The Pivot:**** "I want to be clear that I am not trying to pressure you, but I do want to ensure I'm making the best decision for myself. Since the base salary is fixed, I'd like to explore other areas of the package that might offer more value to me without impacting your cash position."

****The Ask:**** "Could we revisit the non-monetary benefits? Specifically, I'm interested in [Remote Work Flexibility / Title Change / Additional Training Budget]. If we can enhance these areas, I would be happy to accept the salary at the current level."

****Objection Handling 1 (No Flexibility on Any Item):****

"Understood. In that case, I will need some time to review the full package against my other options. I am very interested in this role, but I must ensure the total compensation is fair relative to my market value and current responsibilities."

****Objection Handling 2 (Pressure to Accept Immediately):****

"I appreciate the urgency. However, making a career decision under pressure isn't in either of our best interests."